Phaedra in Delirium

By Susan Yankowitz

INTRODUCTION

There is no such thing as an original play. None of the classical Greek plays was original – they were all based on earlier plays or poems or myths. In the prologue of Euripides' Hippolytus, the goddess, Aphrodite declares herself resolved to punish the Hippolytus, son of Theseus, who disdains her and pays his worship to Artemis. With this design she has put into the heart of Phaedra, the wife of Theseus, a love for her stepson. This Theseus will learn, and then will destroy his son by one of three fatal wishes which Poseidon has promised to fulfill. This will involve the ruin of Phaedra too, but for that there is no help, the goddess caring first for her honor and herself. Adapted from various versions of the myth, it is the story of Phaedra that is told by Susan Yankowitz in this opening scene of Phaedra in Delirium.

FRIEND: Phaedra's sick. For weeks she's been in here, rooted to her bed. Sleeping. Not sleeping. Lady of leisure, or lady of lamentations: lady layabed. She needs me now -- I know she does -- and so I packed my bag and settled in to keep an eye on her. Not that it helps, not that she cares. She barely answers when I talk to her, doesn't drink, doesn't eat, doesn't really see me, and doesn't budge from that bed, as if she didn't know the difference between night and day, day and night. Sometimes I hear her tossing and turning, full of moans and sighs; and the rest of the time--

(PHAEDRA sits there, supported by pillows, looking at herself in a mirror)

--she stares in that mirror, stares and stares, as if she's married to it. But she's not. She's married to Theseus, a wealthy man, a powerful man, Theseus who is away, frequently away, I hear, on

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business, he says, always on business -- but what business can that be? He's almost newlywed, and he lets business seduce him from his home?

(moving closer)

That's what's eating her up, it must be. I'm a woman and her friend; I know these troubles. She feels abandoned, she longs for him, she worries that he regrets the marriage already, that in six months' time he's bored with her, lost himself in a strange woman's lap...

PHAEDRA: *(delirious)* It's so hot in here, I'm suffocating..... asleep, awake, my dreams are heavy with him, my tongue is parched, my lips can't open without his lips near ..... the mountains! I want to go with him to the mountains, to be with him in the air, with the wind on my skin and the rustle of leaves and the silence that has wildness in it, the sense that something could happen ..... anything could happen ..... in the night, in the dark

FRIEND: *(touches her forehead)* Shh. Shhh. The fever's making you talk like this. You're burning up.

PHAEDRA: Good. I'll be consumed, I'll turn to flame, to ash, I'll become pure yes, pure spirit.

FRIEND: You're sick, that's all. People live through sickness and go on to love their lives. Let me call the doctor, get you some medicine.

PHAEDRA: There's no medicine for this.

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FRIEND: It's been three days. You have to eat something.

PHAEDRA: I can't! I'll live on nothing -- or better still, not live at all.

FRIEND: Now why are you so morbid!? The man adores you, worships you. Everyone knows that. So he's away for a while. So it's hard to be without your husband. But it's no tragedy.

PHAEDRA: You! What do you know of tragedy?!

FRIEND: *(offended)* And what do you know of me? I understand suffering, believe me. I'm not ignorant of life. So I never married. I know how to enjoy myself without going crazy. Without driving everyone else crazy! You may love your extremes but I prefer the middle ground.

PHAEDRA: How comforting for you.

FRIEND: You could be comfortable, too. But you won't let yourself. You give in to every feeling, you wallow in your misery as if it were pleasure. What's wrong? Tell me.

PHAEDRA: Please. Go away.

FRIEND: I won't. I'll wait right here until you tell me what's happened. Why else did I come to stay with you? I've been up all night, worrying, worrying; my nerves are shot. What awful news have you heard?

(silence)

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Oh great suffering angel, great mum's-the-word, great martyr of the bleeding silence, talk to me! Is Theseus hurt? In danger of some kind? Speak up! Is he dead?

PHAEDRA: I've heard nothing about Theseus. Nothing at all.

FRIEND: Well, then, why all the fuss? Some women would be thrilled to have their husbands out of town for a while, then suddenly, excitingly, turn up one lonely night and slip between the sheets.

PHAEDRA: Some other woman, maybe. Some other sheets.

FRIEND: So he is with another woman. Don't deny it, I see it in your eyes, that green flame. What did you expect? We all know Theseus. That man never could resist a woman! So what? Who cares if he's having a fling? Look at the fabulous life you have! I've never seen such luxury: this beautiful house, the gardens, horses, a lake...

(strokes the bed linens)

In my entire life, I've never even touched sheets like these.

PHAEDRA: Trust me, you wouldn't want to lie in this bed.

FRIEND: Oh yes, I would. I'd delight in everything you have! Why can't you? You don't have cancer, your heart is strong; I can hear it pounding from here. You're too young for this `sickness unto death'.

PHAEDRA: Too old, you mean, to suffer the petty griefs of love. Come here. Closer. Look. Gravity has her hands on me, she's pulling at my skin, pulling down down down, turning muscle soft and falling off the bone.

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My cheekbones are vanishing. And my hair is losing its color. Do you see? There's a stripe of grey right here.

FRIEND: That's not a disease. It's nature.

PHAEDRA: I hate nature! I hate what she does to us. You'll understand soon enough. Every woman who's reached my age knows what I mean. Suddenly, overnight, we become invisible. We could walk down the street naked and no one would notice. Oh, yes, we can celebrate our `glorious, our liberating maturity' -- but who burns for us now? Who pours out his heart in poetry and midnights? No one. Never. It's obvious: we're the fate that every woman is trying to escape.

FRIEND: You're very beautiful.

PHAEDRA: Beautiful, oh yes -- for a woman my age. That's what people say and think they're being kind. `How beautiful she is for a woman her age!' But I can't fool myself; I have eyes. Everywhere I go I see them, the girls with glowing skin, their faces and throats like unmarked paper, their stomachs little bowls turned inside out.

FRIEND: They'll get older, too, you know.

PHAEDRA: But they have time! They have time now, when they need it! Oh God, how fast it goes. Only yesterday I walked down the road, sending up clouds of musk. My breath was an invitation. No man would have refused me.

FRIEND: Who would refuse you now? No one, no one.

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PHAEDRA: Really?

FRIEND: *Is that* what happened? You met a man and you wanted--?

PHAEDRA: Wanted?! Me? What could I possibly want?! I'm a wife, the wife of Theseus, a great figure in the world, an important man!

FRIEND: And he should be with you. I'm going to track him down. It shouldn't be too hard.

(She exits. PHAEDRA turns around on her bed to face the audience, her head bowed forward under the weight of an enormous mass of hair piled on top.)

PHAEDRA: *(tries to lift her head; she can't)* This hair I can barely lift up my head so neat, so proper, no wisps flying it weighs me down

(Occasionally she succeeds in raising her head but slaps herself down)

Girl ..... run through the fields ..... hair flying ..... unbraid the braids ..... raise the sails ..... let the horses loose ..... slap! grow up! running ..... toes like worms, feet like birds ..... where are your shoes? slap! slap! ..... grow up! ..... can't see the stars the sun the skies ..... the floor is grey and dirty, the ground hits my eyes ..... lift! slap me down! ..... pins in my scalp a torture, pins like needles, needle in the haystack, jumping falling hay in my hair slap! ..... can't go wild, can't go child ..... stop! slap! ..... sit still ..... grown up ..... heavy heavy heavy the head that ..... can't move can't dance can't throw back my head for song or love or..... heavy ..... heavy ..... heavy

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Finally PHAEDRA can lift her head. She is facing the audience. She takes a deep breath, then swirls her hair around and around her with increasing freedom. She pulls down her nightgown so that her bare shoulders are exposed, and lets her hair move over them. Her eyes are closed, and she is smiling, standing in a field of hairpins.

This is how he saw me when he saw me first. This is how I felt, this is how it felt when he saw me first.

(swirls her hair) This is how I want it to feel ..... like hands on me like fingers playing on my skin.

This is who I was when he saw me first.

This is how I felt when --

(IPPOLYTUS appears, dressed in a white linen suit. PHAEDRA turns in his direction. Slowly, as if against her will, she walks toward him. She stands directly in front of him)

So. You're Hippolytus.

(Transfixed, she takes his hands in hers and holds them for a long time)

Hippolytus. You have your father's hands.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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